eight months. Congress leaders claim that their internal surveys are in line with the party's expectations of winning a majority in the next elections.

The underlying conflict between the two, says a party functionary, is visible in the projection of potential candidates in various assembly seats. This rivalry is also something that Karnataka's ruling BJP likes to play up—so much so that, riled by its jibes over his birthday celebrations, Siddaramaiah recently took to Twitter, pointing out the BJP's own internal squabbles in Karnataka.

The equations between Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar have been an ongoing curiosity, and often enough, it is partymen themselves who trigger discussion, like legislator Zameer Ahmed Khan did a couple of months ago when he prayed for Siddaramaiah to become CM again. Back in January, the two leaders had similarly come under close scrutiny during a Congress padayatra, which was seen as Shivakumar's show—the Congress had put up a united face then. Even in April, when Rahul Gandhi visited Bengaluru, his advice to the party leadership was to work unitedly.

The 'Siddaramaiah 75 Amrut Mahotsava' isn't a party function, but an event to celebrate a person who is among the tallest leaders in Karnataka cutting across parties, says former minister Basavaraj Rayareddi, who is part of the committee planning the jamboree. "So, we, his friends and admirers, have decided to celebrate his 75th birthday in a meaningful way."

The plan is to invite cultural figures at the city-wise gatherings at Mysore, Gulbarga and Hubli, while the big rally in Davanagere—which Rahul Gandhi will attend—brings in party workers from across the state. All top Congress leaders in Karnataka, including Shivakumar, will be there, says Rayareddi. "They are not at loggerheads. Everyone has their desires to become a CM, there's nothing wrong with that. It's all unnecessary, false propaganda," he says. ■



WEST BENGAL

# BENGAL'S NREGA JAM

By Romita Datta

Trouble is brewing between the Trinamool Congress government in West Bengal and the NDA-ruled Centre over the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee scheme (NREGA). The state has topped the chart in terms of providing employment under the scheme in 2020-2021, but instead of accolades, it is struggling to pay wages to workers for the last five months of the 2021-22 fiscal. This is because, the state says, the Centre has not released Rs 6,500 crore towards labour payment and cost of material. The Centre disagrees, and argues that the amount was spent on creating an additional three crore mandays without taking prior sanction, as is the practice. Moreover, the Centre has not sanctioned the new NREGA labour budget the state tabled for 2022-23, forcing it to take the unprecedented step of stopping all work under the scheme.

"The decision is impacting 1.4 crore job card holders and the rural economy," says Pulak Roy, minister for panchayats and rural development. Roy adds that dues are now Rs 7,200 crore, since the state had created 2.15 crore mandays this fiscal, even though the scheme's budget was pending. While the TMC government is citing this as an instance of the BJP's hostility to Bengal, that hides a more controversial aspect.